exacerbated by the thought that they were now openly and shamelessly fighting for the throne while he himself was still very much alive. He sent Khurram down from the fort with a message for Salim: ‘Shah Baba (Akbar) says this elephant bout is yours. What is the reason for violence and immoderation?’ Salim pleaded ignorance in the matter and the elephants were finally cooled down by driving them into the placid waters of the Yamuna. The insolence of Salim and his servants’ behaviour seemed to deeply wound the Padshah.

At the age of sixty-three, Akbar’s iron will and his grasp on the affairs of state were finally slackening after almost half a century of rule, his indefatigable and elemental strength suddenly undone. Miniatures depicting him at this time show that his hair had turned white, his expression melancholic, almost resigned. In October of the year, as the summer heat finally resolved itself into a golden light, and the champa trees flowered in the gardens, Akbar fell ill with a stomach complaint. He called his physician, Hakim Ali Gilani, and the hakim, not unwisely, told the Padshah to fast for a day before trying any medicines. The next day, a simple broth without ghee was advised but Akbar felt very weak and retired to the zenana quarters. Khurram tended to his grandfather tirelessly for the entire length of his illness. For ten days no treatment was attempted as the physicians argued among themselves about the best possible remedy to administer to their exalted patient. Weak and debilitated, Akbar continued to present himself for darshan at the jharoka window, as the nobility and townsfolk struggled to think the unthinkable—that the Padshah might be coming to the end of his days. Akbar continued to issue orders by dictating hukms to his writers but, after ten days, a fever began to rage in the Padshah’s weakened body. As the physicians decided on who should treat the emperor, probably terrified of doing more harm than good at this critical stage, Akbar favoured Hakim Ali. ‘We have trusted our person to Hakim Ali,’ he said. ‘Let him do what he thinks right.’

In the midst of this maelstrom of suspicion and distrust, the thirteen-year-old Khurram demonstrated an unshakeable resolve, remarkable in someone so young. Khurram was, at this age, a smooth-faced boy with his father’s long, straight nose and the large eyes and arched eyebrows of Rajput miniatures. ‘Prince Khurram stood his ground in the midst of enemies and malevolents,’ wrote an admiring Salim, ‘and refused to leave his grandfather. Although his mother sent numerous messages telling him